

WEEKLY JOURNAL DIGEST

Weekly journal digest for 2026-05-25 to 2026-05-31

Curated articles in political communication and computational social science.

SUMMARY

COMAP Journal Bot reviewed 325 collected candidates for the 2026-05-25 to 2026-05-31 digest window. After manual relevance filtering, the curated no-send preview keeps 40 papers: 22 new this week, 18 previous-week catch-up items, and 0 late additions.

This week is especially strong on platforms as political infrastructure. The new papers include work on social media data access, gendered algorithmic underrepresentation in political Google searches, a national-election algorithm redesign experiment, technology-mediated child sexual exploitation and abuse, and two pieces on how AI systems are entering research practice. The broader social-science thread is also solid: immigration preferences, peer influence, public administration, one-child policy effects on inequality, and governance risks around sycophantic advice all make the cut.

- Platform governance and algorithmic political communication are the clearest through-line in the new material.
- AI-for-computational-social-science papers focus less on speculation and more on adoption, reproducibility, and measurement practice.
- The catch-up section is mostly policy, misinformation, censorship, mobility, and political-methods work from the previous publication week.

HIGHLIGHTS

Moving Targets, Moving Politics: The State of Play in Social Media Data Access

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-05-30

Claes H. de Vreese; Rebekah Tromble

Why it matters · Platform access is now a political object in its own right; this piece is directly relevant to social-media data governance and computational political communication.

[Open article →](#)

The Prevalence and Consequences of Women's Algorithmic Underrepresentation in Cross-National Political Google Searches

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-05-27

Tobias Rohrbach; Mykola Makhortykh; Maryna Sydorova

Why it matters · A sharp fit for multimodal and algorithmic political communication: it connects search infrastructures to gendered visibility in cross-national political information environments.

[Open article →](#)

Redesigning algorithms to intervene on social norm misperceptions during a national election

NATURE · 2026-05-27

William J. Brady; Meriel Doyle; Abdo Elnakouri; Eli J. Finkel; Joshua Conrad Jackson; et al. (11 total)

Why it matters · A rare large-platform intervention study during a national election, squarely on algorithmic ranking, polarization, and perceived social norms.

[Open article →](#)

Technology mediation in child sexual exploitation and abuse in Africa and Asia

NATURE · 2026-05-27

Sakshi Ghai; Matti Vuorre; Daniel Kardefelt-Winther; Amanda M. Ferguson; Sebastian Kurten; et al. (8 total)

Why it matters · The paper gives cross-national evidence on technology-mediated digital harms among children, with clear implications for online safety policy and platform governance.

[Open article →](#)

The diffusion of large language models in published academic articles

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-05-29

Kyle Siler

Why it matters · Useful for AI-for-CSS work because it measures LLM adoption across millions of articles and links uptake to institutional conditions.

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AI-assisted teams outperform AI-led teams but not human-only teams in assessing research reproducibility in quantitative social science

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-05-28

Abel Brodeur; David Valenta; Alexandru Marcoci; Juan P. Aparicio; Derek Mikola; et al. (272 total)

Why it matters · Directly relevant to computational social science infrastructure: it tests how AI assistance changes reproducibility work in quantitative social science.

[Open article →](#)

Which immigrants do citizens prefer? A meta-reanalysis of 100 conjoint experiments

SCIENCE ADVANCES · 2026-05-29

Marco Avina; Taeku Lee; Mashail Malik; Reed Rasband; Marcel F. Roman; et al. (6 total)

Why it matters · A major synthesis of conjoint evidence on immigration preferences, valuable for public-opinion, migration, and survey-experiment work.

[Open article →](#)

Rational sycophants and catastrophic risks

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-05-26

Robert Axelrod; Scott E. Page

Why it matters · A compact governance model of sycophancy, leadership incentives, and catastrophic policy risk that travels well beyond its formal setting.

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Previous Week Catch-Up

- [Journal of Communication](#)
- [Political Communication](#)
- [American Journal of Political Science](#)
- [Political Analysis](#)
- [Nature](#)
- [Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences](#)
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- [Nature Communications](#)

COLLECTION SNAPSHOT		
TOTAL COLLECTED CANDIDATES 325	NEW THIS WEEK CANDIDATES 162	PREVIOUS WEEK CATCH-UP CANDIDATES 163
LATE ADDITIONS CANDIDATES 0	CURATED DIGEST BELOW 22 new, 18 catch-up, 0 late additions	NOTE The full collected set above is before manual relevance filtering, while the HTML preview and PDF reflect the curated digest.

FULL CURATED DIGEST

New This Week

Journal of Communication

Modes of dialogic communication, modes of reality

2026-05-29 · DOI 10.1093/JOC/JQAG006

Boris H J M Brummans

Department of Communication, Universite de Montreal , Montreal, QC,

Abstract. Abstract What if dialogue didn't begin with individuals trying to connect, but with a deeper connectedness already unfolding? This theoretical essay explores that question by introducing two modes of dialogic communication, each expressing the ground of experience in a distinct way. Drawing on Buddhist philosophy, particularly Dzogchen, process philosophy, and traditions of dialogic thought, it proposes awaring as the emergent process through which the ground of experience arises. In the dialogue mode, grasping at this unfolding reinforces separation, making reality appear as an exchange between distinct selves seeking understanding. In the dialoguing mode, we recognize the ground's inherent openness, in which voices, gestures, thoughts, and silences co-arise, making reality appear more spacious, relational, and compassionate. Structured in three spiraling movements (ground: awaring, expression: dialoguing, and fruit: recognizing), the essay culminates in a generative conversation with Arnett, Bencherki and Senac, Cooren, and Peters, inviting a reimagining of dialogic communication theory and a deepened study of communicative relationality.

[Read article →](#)**Technology and face-to-face integration in daily life: an intensive longitudinal study of communication interdependence**

2026-05-25 · DOI 10.1093/JOC/JQAG005

Liesel L Sharabi; Elizabeth Dorrance-Hall; John P Caughlin; Alan K Goodboy; Rebekah M Chiasson

Department of Communication Studies, West Virginia University, Morgantown, WV, United States; Department of Communication, Michigan State University , East Lansing, MI.; Department of Communication, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, Urbana, IL, United States; Department of Marketing, Agribusiness, and Supply Chain Management, University of Nebraska Kearney, Kearney, NE, United States; Hugh Downs School of Human Communication, Arizona State University , Tempe, AZ,

Abstract. Abstract The current study advances the communication interdependence perspective (CIP) using an intensive longitudinal design and recent refinements in the conceptualization of integration (i.e., how various channels are interconnected). U.S. adults in romantic relationships (N = 175) completed a baseline questionnaire, and then, provided daily diary data over 30 days (4,806 total observations), which we analyzed with dynamic structural equation modeling. Consistent with the CIP, for the typical person, constructive integration had a positive within-person effect (i.e., people felt closer on days that they had more constructive integration than usual) and a positive between-person association (i.e., people with more constructive integration reported more relational closeness on average across the month). Additionally, there was persistence in constructive integration, and persistence was stronger for people who reported more habitual patterns of integration earlier in the month. We discuss the implications for the CIP and for understanding how people mix media in daily life.

[Read article →](#)

Political Communication

Moving Targets, Moving Politics: The State of Play in Social Media Data Access

2026-05-30 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2681041

Claes H. de Vreese; Rebekah Tromble

Northeastern University; Universiteit van Amsterdam

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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The Prevalence and Consequences of Women's Algorithmic Underrepresentation in Cross-National Political Google Searches

2026-05-27 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2679476

Tobias Rohrbach; Mykola Makhortykh; Maryna Sydorova

University of Bern; University of Fribourg

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Nature

Redesigning algorithms to intervene on social norm misperceptions during a national election

2026-05-27 · DOI 10.1038/S41586-026-10536-1

William J. Brady; Meriel Doyle; Abdo Elnakouri; Eli J. Finkel; Joshua Conrad Jackson; Nour Kteily; Victoria Parker; Curtis Puryear; Trevor Spelman; Jacob Teeny; Mark Torres

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Technology mediation in child sexual exploitation and abuse in Africa and Asia

2026-05-27 · DOI 10.1038/S41586-026-10525-4

Sakshi Ghai; Matti Vuorre; Daniel Kardefelt-Winther; Amanda M. Ferguson; Sebastian Kurten; Sonia Livingstone; Andrew K. Przybylski; Amy Orben

Abstract. Abstract As digital access expands rapidly among children worldwide, technology-facilitated child sexual exploitation and abuse (CSEA), including online grooming, sexual solicitation, non-consensual image sharing and sexual extortion, has emerged as urgent yet underexamined category of digital harms 1 . Despite growing policy attention to online safety, evidence remains limited, particularly in low- and middle-income countries, where most of the world's children live 2 . We analysed nationally representative survey data from 11,912 children aged 12-17 years across 12 countries in eastern and southern Africa and Southeast Asia, collected through the Disrupting Harm project in 2020-2021. We found that one in six internet-using children experienced at least one form of technology-facilitated CSEA, equivalent to over 10 million children. Despite this scale, many experiences went undisclosed, pointing to disclosure as a critical pathway for protection in the digital age. When children did disclose, they relied primarily on informal channels, especially friends, rather than formal reporting mechanisms such as police or helplines. Using Bayesian hierarchical models accounting for cross-country heterogeneity, we find that older children were less likely to disclose, whereas enabling parental mediation of online activities and children's knowledge of where to seek help after sexual harassment or assault were associated with higher rates of disclosure. These findings provide population-level evidence to inform prevention and response across low- and middle-income countries, where coordinated action by policymakers, law enforcement and technology companies is urgently needed to protect all children.

[Read article →](#)

Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

The cost of caring: Gendered health and labor market effects of grandparenthood

2026-05-29 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2535409123

Maria Lyster Andersen; Rannveig Kaldager Hart; Hans Fredrik Sunde; Neil Martin Davies; Fartein Ask Torvik

Centre for Fertility and Health, Norwegian Institute of Public Health; Department of Health Management and Health Economics, Institute of Health and Society, University of Oslo; Department of Psychology, University of Oslo; Department of Public Health and Nursing, Norwegian University of Science and Technology; Division of Psychiatry, Department of Statistics, University College London; Promenta Research Center, Department of Psychology, University of Oslo

Abstract. While the effects of the transition to parenthood are well researched, less is known about how the transition to grandparenthood affects health and labor market outcomes. Using comprehensive Norwegian register data covering the entire population born between 1950 and 1960, we examine the effects of first-born grandchildren born during 2007-2018. Employing event-study models with person-year records, we compare grandparents to not-yet grandparents. Our findings reveal a sharp increase in the likelihood of respiratory infections during the first two years of grandparenthood, with infections increasing by 56% for women and 31% for men. Additionally, grandparenthood modestly reduces the likelihood of doctor's visits related to mental disorders (4.5%) and cardiovascular health (3.3%). Grandmothers also see a decline in musculoskeletal-related visits (3.8%). These health-related changes coincide with notable gendered effects on labor market participation. Ten years after the birth of their first grandchild, employed women are 12% less likely to hold full-time positions compared to a 2% reduction for men. Overall, our findings demonstrate that the transition to grandparenthood significantly reshapes health and economic outcomes for both women and men. The larger effects observed for women likely reflect their greater involvement in informal childcare provision. Our results underscore the intersection of health, family dynamics, and gendered labor market behaviors in late adulthood.

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The diffusion of large language models in published academic articles

2026-05-29 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2605754123

Kyle Siler

Department of Leadership, Higher and Adult Education, Ontario Institute for Studies in Education, Data, Equity and Policy in Education Lab, University of Toronto

Abstract. Large language models (LLMs) are rapidly changing academic research, raising questions of who is adopting these tools and under what conditions. This article analyzes full texts of 7.3 million journal articles published from 2020-2025 by four major publishers (Elsevier, Frontiers, MDPI, and PLoS) to track the prevalence of LLM-associated language and identify social and institutional correlates of adoption. A corpus of 228 focal words exhibiting sharp post-2022 frequency increases consistent with LLM output was developed; articles were scored on their rate of focal word usage. By 2025, an estimated 57% of published articles exhibited evidence of LLM influence, up from 12% in 2023. Among articles exhibiting LLM-influenced text, there is substantial heterogeneity, ranging from subtle linguistic influence to articles mostly or entirely LLM-generated. Difference-in-differences models reveal that LLM-associated language varies markedly across regions, institutional ranks, publishers, disciplines, and journal tiers. Economic development and proximity to English as a primary language are key predictors of regional variation. Lower-ranked institutions exhibit higher rates than elite universities, young for-profit publishers show elevated rates vis-a-vis competitors, and academic fields differ widely in adoption. LLM adoption in academic writing is pervasive but socially stratified. As models grow more powerful and their use becomes further entrenched in academic research, understanding social dynamics of adoption will be essential for governing the evolving relationship between AI and academic knowledge production.

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What leads to administrative bloat? A dynamic model of administrative cost and waste

2026-05-29 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2527106123

Vicky Chuqiao Yang; Levi Grenier

Institute for Data, Systems, and Society; MIT Sloan School of Management; Massachusetts Institute of Technology

Abstract. The functioning of complex systems depends on the coordination of diverse components, often supported by regulatory structures that incur costs. In human organizations, such costs manifest as administrative burden, which has been rising despite often reducing efficiency. Classic explanations point to bureaucrat self-interest or regulation, yet they do not explain variation across organizations or clarify how this burden can be reduced. Here, we develop a dynamical model of administrative growth that integrates known behavioral mechanisms of process creation, obsolescence, and removal. The model conceptualizes processes as developed for problem solving, but becoming obsolete as conditions change, while continuing to consume resources until actively pruned. This interplay generates two long-term outcomes: stable equilibrium or run-away growth. The threshold separating these outcomes is shaped by organizations' propensity to create new processes when faced with problems, and their propensity to prune obsolete ones in response to administrative burden. Importantly, their effects are asymmetric: Sufficiently high creation propensity leads to bloat regardless of pruning propensity. Faster environmental change shifts this threshold, making bloat more likely. Simulations of interventions show that lasting reductions in administrative costs and waste require permanent shifts in priorities and investments in distinguishing obsolete from useful processes. Temporary efforts or indiscriminate cuts provide only short-lived relief, and counterintuitively, prioritizing direct production can increase waste. Our work highlights a general mechanism by which well-intentioned problem-solving can create self-reinforcing inefficiencies in complex systems, offering insights possibly generalizable to broader applications, such as legal, policy, and software systems where obsolete elements accumulate.

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AI-assisted teams outperform AI-led teams but not human-only teams in assessing research reproducibility in quantitative social science

2026-05-28 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2524747123

Abel Brodeur; David Valenta; Alexandru Marcoci; Juan P. Aparicio; Derek Mikola; Bruno Barbarioli; Rohan Alexander; Lachlan Deer; Tom Stafford; Lars Vilhuber; Gunther Bensch; Fabio Motoki; et al. (272 total)

Aalto University; Agri-Science Queensland, Department of Primary Industries, Brisbane; Applied Economics and Management, Cornell University; Applied Economics, University of Minnesota; Asia and Pacific Department, International Monetary Fund; Bart's Life Sciences, Bart's Health National Health Services Trust; Behavioral Science, Geary Institute for Public Policy; Beijing Normal University, Belt and Road School; Birkbeck Business School, Birkbeck, University of London; Business School, Beijing Normal University; Business School, Universidad Adolfo Ibanez; Business School, Universidad de los Andes; et al. (254 total affiliations)

Abstract. Large Language Models (LLMs) such as ChatGPT are transforming how scientists conduct and validate research, offering promise as tools to improve scientific reproducibility. However, computational reproducibility and error detection remain expensive and labor-intensive. We experimentally test how collaboration between researchers and LLM assistants influences the reproduction of quantitative social science findings across different levels of AI autonomy. We randomly assigned 288 researchers to 103 teams working under three conditions: human-only, AI-assisted (using ChatGPT as a collaborative tool), or AI-led (ChatGPT operating with minimal human oversight). Teams reproduced published results from leading social science journals, detected coding errors, and proposed robustness checks. Human-only and AI-assisted teams achieved comparable reproduction rates (94% vs. 91%) and performed similarly on most outcomes, except human-only teams identified significantly more major coding errors. Both substantially outperformed AI-led teams, which achieved only a 37% reproduction rate, detected fewer errors across all categories, proposed weaker robustness checks, and required more time. This autonomous approach, however, likely represents only a lower bound of AI capabilities. Despite rapid model advances, expert human judgment currently remains indispensable for reliable empirical verification. While AI assistance did not degrade most outcomes, it provided no measurable advantages and was associated with reduced detection of major errors. However, the 37% autonomous reproduction rate indicates that AI could provide value in settings where scale or cost constraints preclude human review of papers, even though general-purpose LLMs offer no immediate advantages for

human-supervised verification.

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Early neural attunement to peer status predicts future social network position and popularity in adolescents

2026-05-27 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2536452123

Won-Gyo Shin; Kiho Sung; Junho Bang; Sunhae Sul; Yoosik Youm; Carolyn Parkinson

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Abstract. Popularity is a key marker of social status, yet the phenomena that support its emergence within newly forming social groups remain unclear. We combined functional neuroimaging and longitudinal school-wide social network analysis to track adolescents throughout their first year of high school, examining whether early neural responses to peers of varying social status predict later popularity. Here, we show that greater neural differentiation when viewing the faces of unpopular versus popular peers, particularly in the hippocampus, forecasts greater perceived popularity at the end of the school year. This relationship is mediated by midyear social network centrality, especially in-closeness centrality, which reflects being more easily reachable by peers. These findings suggest that early neural attunement to the status of their peers shapes how adolescents become embedded in their social networks, which in turn contributes to later gains in their own perceived popularity. More generally, these findings reveal how neural and social network-level processes jointly drive adolescents' navigation of evolving social landscapes and attainment of social status.

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Neural representations of popularity and leadership status relate to conformity in daily life

2026-05-27 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2526584123

Ovidia A. Stanoi; Danielle Cosme; Mia Jovanova; Yoona Kang; Faustine Corbani; Amanda L. McGowan; Jose Carreras-Tartak; Anthony Resnick; Peter S. Bearman; Zachary M. Boyd; Dani S. Bassett; David M. Lydon-Staley; et al. (15 total)

Annenberg Public Policy Center, University of Pennsylvania; Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania; Centre for Digital Health Interventions, Department of Management, Technology and Economics, ETH Zurich; Department of Bioengineering, University of Pennsylvania; Department of Mathematics, Brigham Young University; Department of Mathematics, Dartmouth College; Department of Psychology, Columbia University; Department of Psychology, Princeton University; Department of Psychology, Rutgers University; Department of Psychology, University of Pennsylvania; Department of Sociology, Columbia University; School of Medicine, University of St. Gallen; et al. (13 total affiliations)

Abstract. Individuals are motivated to increase their social status. To succeed in this pursuit, people must track information about others in their social sphere, monitor group norms, and adjust their behavior strategically. This study employed functional MRI and ecological momentary assessment methods in a sample of 92 college students belonging to 9 social groups to elucidate the neural mechanisms underlying these processes and their relationship to conformity in the context of alcohol use. When young adults passively looked at faces of their real-life social group peers, brain systems implicated in valuation and social cognition spontaneously tracked information about the popularity and leadership status of the social targets in an interdependent manner. Individual differences in these neural valuations were systematically associated with varying levels of conformity. Students who had stronger responses to faces of peers with relatively higher popularity and leadership status than themselves in one key valuation brain region, the ventromedial prefrontal cortex (vmPFC), were more likely to align their drinking behavior with their groups' norms in everyday life. These results provide evidence for how brain systems involved in valuation and social cognition flexibly track information about peers' popularity and leadership status in real-life social groups and contribute to a growing literature on the neural mechanisms through which social comparison processes shape conformity. Our study highlights the vmPFC as a central hub that spontaneously tracks status differences between the self and peers and uses this information to guide behavior to match group norms.

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Peer influence on West Point cadets' Civil War allegiances

2026-05-27 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2529668123

Yuchen Guo; Matthew O. Jackson; Ruixue Jia

Centre for Economic Policy Research; Department of Economics, Stanford University; Department of Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shatin, New Territories; National Bureau of Economic Research; Santa Fe Institute; School of Global Policy and Strategy, University of California San Diego; The Chinese University of Hong Kong-University of California San Diego Joint Laboratory on Chinese Economy, Shatin, New Territories

Abstract. Do social networks and peer influence shape major life decisions in polarized settings? We explore this question by examining how peers influenced the allegiances of West Point cadets during the American Civil War. Leveraging quasi-random variations in the proportion of cadets from Free States, we analyze how cadets' decisions about which army to join depended on the composition of their peers. We have three main findings. First, there was a strong and significant peer effect: a higher proportion of classmates from Free States significantly increased the likelihood that cadets from Slave States joined the Union Army. Second, the peer effect varies with geography, most notably with the slave population share in cadets' home states or counties, and with cadets' own slave ownership in 1860. Third, peer effects were amplified by shared experiences such as having served together in the Mexican-American War, continuous military service, and belonging to the same cohort, suggesting that sustained interaction is important.

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Accessibility-equality dynamics in urban blue and green spaces reshape human well-being

2026-05-26 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2535714123

Bin Xue; Jianing Zhang; Bingsheng Liu; Marina Alberti; Yufeng Fan; Dong Zhao; Nancy B. Grimm

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Abstract. As urbanization accelerates, urban blue and green spaces are increasingly recognized as critical nature-based solutions for enhancing human well-being, delivering climate, environmental, and psychological benefits. Yet, the mechanisms by which access to these natural spaces and the equality of access by urbanites in diverse residential locations shape well-being remain poorly understood in the context of sustainable urban governance. Here, we systematically evaluated the spatiotemporal dynamics of urban blue and green space accessibility and equality across 279 Chinese cities from 2000-2100 and assessed their combined effects on well-being. We found that accessibility has a significant positive influence on well-being but follows an inverted-U-shaped pattern with distinct optimal thresholds. By contrast, equality shows a consistent, positive linear relationship with well-being. Although future accessibility is projected to improve, persistently high disparities among different segments of urban populations highlight the urgent need for equity-centered governance of blue and green spaces in cities. This perspective extends current approaches to environmental justice while revealing a structural mismatch between resource abundance and equitable distribution. To address this mismatch, we propose a prioritization framework that emphasizes context-specific, spatially targeted interventions, guided by four key drivers: the natural space to built-up area ratio, urban population size, the proportion of natural spaces with high accessibility, and urban landscape connectivity. By operationalizing these insights in an online toolkit for local governments, this work advances the fields of sustainable urban governance and equitable environmental planning.

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China's one-child policy amplifies intergenerational inequality via enlarged differential fertility

2026-05-26 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2525381123

Yewen Yu; Yi Fan; Junjian Yi

China Center of Economic Research, Peking University; Department of Economics, School of Economics, Beijing Technology and Business University; Department of Real Estate, Business School, National University of Singapore; Institute for Advanced Study, Wuhan University; Institute for Global Health and Development, Peking University; National School of Development, Peking University

Abstract. Using the staggered rollout of China's one-child policy (OCP) across provinces and birth cohorts as a quasi-natural experiment, we demonstrate that differential fertility between richer and poorer households exacerbates intergenerational income inequality. Rural/poorer families, who are less constrained by the OCP than their urban/richer counterparts, tend to have more children but invest less in each child's human capital. This reduction in mobility is primarily driven by the rising economic status of children born to urban/wealthier families. Our estimates suggest that the OCP accounts for approximately 25% of the observed decline in intergenerational income mobility in China and thus highlight a demographic channel through which economic inequality persists across generations.

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Emerging design principles for environmental, economic, and equity successes in land conservation

2026-05-26 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2421731122

Katharine R. E. Sims; Jennifer M. Alix-Garcia

Applied Economics, Oregon State University; Economics and Environmental Studies, Amherst College

Abstract. Land conservation initiatives worldwide are poised to continue rapid growth. Ranging in scale, scope, and mechanisms, these efforts include area-based conservation, incentive-based protection, and community collective management. Evidence from across fields now indicates that it is possible for land conservation to jointly improve environmental conditions, generate positive net local economic benefits, and support social equity. Yet the key policy elements that can lead to this type of multidimensional success are not well understood. Here, we review the considerable body of existing research on land conservation and propose eight emerging design principles that conservation actors can employ to support "win-win-win" outcomes: 1) identify and support credible pathways of change, 2) set goals for all outcomes, recognizing their interdependencies, 3) accommodate multiple needs and uses through spatial or place-specific differentiation, 4) facilitate temporal resilience through diversification and limits, 5) foster nested governance, 6) integrate information structures for environmental and social outcomes, 7) assess policies using counterfactual-based analysis and adaptive management, 8) establish lasting institutions and funding mechanisms. Although these design principles will likely change and evolve, they provide an evidence-grounded framework to support current and future efforts to steward global lands.

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Rational sycophants and catastrophic risks

2026-05-26 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2537944123

Robert Axelrod; Scott E. Page

Ford School of Public Policy, University of Michigan; Ross School of Business, Santa Fe Institute

Abstract. Sycophants praise and support leaders' proposals to gain personal and professional advantage. A rational sycophant is an advisor who supports actions they expect to be harmful even when rewards and punishments for good and bad advice are equal in magnitude. Rational sycophancy arises when the outcome distribution of a proposed action has a negative expected value but a positive median (outcome asymmetry). The risk is greatest when a small yet meaningful fraction of outcomes are catastrophic, which occurs in long-tailed distributions. Given that single realizations from long-tailed distributions reveal little about the underlying distribution, even after outcomes are observed, a leader may be unable to distinguish rational sycophancy from wise counsel. As a result, rational sycophants may gain influence and increase the likelihood of catastrophic policy outcomes.

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Semantic knowledge guides innovation and drives cultural evolution

2026-05-26 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2530750123

Anil Yaman; Shen Tian; Bjorn Lindstrom

Computer Science Department, Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam; Department of Clinical Neuroscience, Division of Psychology, Karolinska Institutet

Abstract. Cultural evolution allows ideas and technologies to accumulate across generations, reaching their most complex and open-ended form in humans. While social learning enables the transmission of such innovations, the cognitive processes that generate them remain poorly understood. Classical theories typically treat innovation as random variation, a simplification insufficient for explaining the complexity of human cultural evolution. We propose that semantic knowledge—the associations linking concepts to their properties and functions—guides human innovation and drives cumulative culture. To test this, we combined an agent-based model, which examines how semantic knowledge shapes cultural evolutionary dynamics, with a large-scale behavioral experiment ($N = 1,243$) testing its role in human innovation. Across both approaches, we found that semantic knowledge directed exploration toward meaningful solutions, enhanced innovation success, and enabled generalization from prior discoveries. Moreover, semantic knowledge interacted synergistically with social learning to amplify innovation and accelerate cumulative cultural change. In contrast, experimental participants lacking access to semantic knowledge performed no better than chance, even when social learning was possible, and relied on shallow exploration strategies for innovation. Together, these findings suggest that semantic knowledge is a key cognitive process underpinning human cumulative culture.

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Science Advances

Which immigrants do citizens prefer? A meta-reanalysis of 100 conjoint experiments

2026-05-29 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.ADZ2271

Marco Avina; Taeku Lee; Mashail Malik; Reed Rasband; Marcel F. Roman; Priyanka Sethy

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Abstract. In the past decade, an important literature in the social sciences has examined public attitudes toward immigrants in host societies. In it, a prominent experimental method—the conjoint design, where participants are tasked with rating or choosing between randomized profiles—has been used reliably to understand how immigrant characteristics shape admission preferences. We collate replication datasets from 100 individual studies spanning 1,475,403 immigrant profiles with 26 randomized attributes evaluated by 142,817 survey respondents from 36 countries. Meta-analyses reinforce well-established findings: Economic, cultural, humanitarian, and procedural factors all influence evaluations. Meta-reanalyses show that preferences are broadly similar across countries and demographic groups. However, they also reveal two additional patterns: Economic considerations have become more influential over time, and evaluations of individual immigrants differ sharply depending on where people stand on the broader immigration debate. These findings shed light on ongoing debates and point to fruitful areas for future research.

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Nature Human Behaviour

Methodological considerations for evaluating policy impacts on transgender and non-binary youth suicidality

2026-05-28 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02467-8

J. Cohn; Peter Sim; Kathleen F. Kerr

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Nature Communications

Critical misalignments in climate pledges reveal imbalanced sustainable development pathways

2026-05-27 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-73564-5

Francesca Larosa; Lamyae A. Rhomrassi; Sergio Hoyas; J. Alberto Conejero; Javier Garcia-Martinez; Fermin Mallor; Francesco Fuso Nerini; Ricardo Vinuesa

Abstract. Abstract We explore the integration of climate action and Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) in the first two submissions of nationally determined contributions (NDCs) using an AI-based, human-validated framework. Our goal is to provide ex-ante evidence relevant to assessing policy adequacy. We find disparities in topics of interest with high-income countries emphasizing systemic challenges (health, SDG3) and low-income nations prioritizing the water-energy-food nexus (SDGs 6-7-12) and natural resource management (SDG15). We discuss what these diverging development trajectories imply for the Paris Agreement and the 2030 Agenda for sustainable development in terms of global inequality, sustainable finance flows and multilateral governance.

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Nature Machine Intelligence

Human-AI interactions reshape the self and our social networks

2026-05-28 · DOI 10.1038/S42256-026-01248-2

Andreia Sofia Teixeira; Sukhwinder Singh Shergill; Guy Laban

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Previous Week Catch-Up

Journal of Communication

Techno-refusal as a generative orientation to the future

2026-05-24 · DOI 10.1093/JOC/JQAG003

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Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Revisiting "Communication Theory as a Field"

2026-05-22 · DOI 10.1093/JOC/JQAG007

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Abstract. Abstract This article revisits Robert T. Craig's "Communication Theory as a Field" on its 25th anniversary to reassess its relevance for contemporary communication studies. It foregrounds mediation and communication technologies' role in shaping how scholars think and write about communication. Focusing on the 1990s media environment, the analysis draws on Walter Ong's insights into the sensory, technological, and historical conditions of knowledge production. "Communication Theory as a Field" is shown to echo the spatial-visualist logics of Web 1.0. A comparative reading with Peter Ramus highlights the unintended visualism of Craig's project and challenges the ocular paradigm long dominant in communication theory. The article advances communication-as-constitutive perspectives by advocating a "sensory rapprochement" that restores auditory, embodied, and dialogic dimensions to theory while underscoring the need for reflexivity about how evolving technologies shape disciplinary frameworks and the conditions of theorizing.

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Political Communication

Press and Prejudice: an Interview Study on Politicians' Perceptions of Partisan News Media Bias

2026-05-21 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2675595

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Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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The Hostile Misinformation Effect: How Ideological Congruence Drives the Assessment of Misinformation Targets

2026-05-18 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2671760

Patrick van Erkel; Michael Hameleers; Aqsa Farooq; Katjana Gattermann; Marina Tulin; Elske van den Hoogen; Claes de Vreese

University of Amsterdam

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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American Journal of Political Science

Breaking barriers: How an international treaty for women reduces the size of the informal economy

2026-05-19 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70065

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Abstract. Abstract Prior research on the role the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW) has improving women's outcomes has shown ratification results in increased political and social rights, yet no improvements in economic rights. I challenge prior findings by providing evidence that CEDAW improves women's economic rights by reducing gendered legal barriers to employment. I also demonstrate CEDAW has unexpected but desirable downstream consequences that further improve women's economic outcomes by facilitating movement from the informal to the formal economy. Through matching within a difference-in-differences design, I show ratifying countries experience a significant increase in women's equality of economic opportunity and a significant decrease in the size of the informal economy. These results hold under multiple robustness checks and placebo tests. By examining specific outcomes

that are relevant to CEDAW, I offer greater insight into CEDAW's impact on women's economic outcomes than previous research has afforded.

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Postinstrument bias

2026-05-19 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70064

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Abstract. Abstract When using instrumental variables, researchers often assume that causal effects are only identified conditional on covariates. We show that the role of these covariates is often unclear and that there exists confusion regarding their ability to mitigate violations of the exclusion restriction. We explain when and how existing adjustment strategies may lead to "postinstrument" bias. We then discuss assumptions that are sufficient to identify various treatment effects when adjustment for postinstrument variables is required. In general, these assumptions are highly restrictive, albeit they sometimes are testable. We also show that other existing tests are possibly misleading. Then, we introduce a sensitivity analysis that uses information on variables influenced by the instrument to gauge the effect of potential violations of the exclusion restriction. We illustrate it using a published study and summarize our results in easy-to-understand guidelines.

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Political Analysis

Estimating Treatment Effects on Proportions with Synthetic Controls

2026-05-21 · DOI 10.1017/PAN.2026.10046

Konstantin Bogatyrev; Lukas F. Stoetzer

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Abstract. Abstract Synthetic control methods are widely used for causal inference in case studies and panel data settings, often applied to model counterfactuals for proportional outcomes. However, conventional synthetic control methods are designed for univariate outcomes, leading researchers to model counterfactuals for each proportion separately. We make the case for jointly estimating synthetic controls across multiple compositional outcomes. Using the same weights for each proportion establishes a constant control comparison, improving comparability while adhering to compositional constraints on treatment effects. We illustrate the benefits of the method through a simulation and two applications to recent empirical studies. This implementation integrates naturally with a wide range of synthetic control approaches, providing interpretable estimates for compositional panel data common in political science.

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Nature

NoTrue, Silence and Rubbish Communications: satirical journals give Chinese academics a pressure valve

2026-05-20 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-01548-Y

Xiaoying You

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

Cultural evolution of beauty standards

2026-05-21 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2602380123

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Abstract. Beauty standards shape self-perception and health through social comparison and objectification, while exposure to idealized imagery exacerbates body-image concerns. Media and fashion are central arbiters of these ideals, yet long-term, quantitative, intersectional studies on how representation has changed remain scarce. We assembled a dataset of 793,199 records spanning 25 y of advertising, magazine covers, runway shows, and editorials to quantify changes in anthropometric and demographic representation. We find a paradox in the evolution of beauty ideals: While representational diversity has increased, the median model physique remains stable. This is driven by selective plus-size inclusion at the upper tail, while the typical physique continues to diverge from the US population. Intersectionally, non-White models are 4.5 times more likely to be plus-size, suggesting that the industry consolidates multiple markers of diversity onto already underrepresented individuals rather than broadening inclusion structurally. Stratifying the industry via a data-driven prestige hierarchy, we find that thinness is overrepresented at the top tier. Finally, descriptive comparisons of two regulatory interventions suggest that numeric thresholds may be more effective than flexible guidelines at reducing underweight appearances. Our results quantify the cultural evolution in media and fashion, revealing that inclusion has increased; however, gains are uneven and intersectionally concentrated on size and ethnicity, whereas the prevailing thin ideal remains largely unchanged.

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From free speech advocates to critics: The Trump administration's new rhetoric promotes support for censorship among Trump voters

2026-05-21 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2532084123

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Abstract. Most Americans claim to support freedom of speech, including President Donald Trump who has portrayed himself as an ardent defender of this constitutional right. However, in the wake of Charlie Kirk's assassination, Trump and members of his administration began to explicitly call for speech restrictions. This largely unprecedented rhetoric from a sitting president and his allies provides an opportunity to examine competing theories of public opinion: the influence of partisan elites versus the public's purported commitment to free speech. In a preregistered survey experiment, we found that exposure to such unusually explicit antispeech rhetoric increased Trump voters' support for government censorship of outparty media and individuals but prompted backlash among non-Trump voters, increasing their support for protecting outparty speech. While prior research has established that partisans favor censorship of outparty members, we demonstrate that partisans differentially shifted their censorship attitudes in response to the Trump administration's new rhetoric, whether or not the source was attributed to Trump and his allies. These findings highlight the influence of elite rhetoric on public support for even the most foundational-and popular-democratic norm, raising concerns about the resilience of American democracy in the face of explicitly illiberal elites.

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Wind turbine proximity and health: Longitudinal evidence from US households

2026-05-19 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2525715123

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Abstract. Rapid growth of wind energy plays a key role in global efforts to reduce carbon emissions, yet public concerns persist about its potential health effects, particularly through noise exposure. While some studies and media reports suggest that wind turbines may contribute to sleep disturbances, anxiety, and even suicide, existing evidence remains limited and inconclusive. This study combines geolocated data on turbines from the US Wind Turbine Database with longitudinal survey data on over 120,000 households (2011-2023) and consumer purchasing records to assess whether proximity to wind turbines affects mental and physical health. We examine a wide range of outcomes, including depression, anxiety, sleep disorders, headaches, and use of sleep aids and painkillers. Comparing households before and after nearby turbine installations, we find no detectable adverse health effects from turbine exposure at typical exposure distances. While we cannot rule out small effects, our CIs exclude moderate-to-large impacts, suggesting that fears about substantial health impacts are not borne out in population-level data. Other disamenities such as noise, shadow flicker, and visual intrusion may still affect quality of life even absent measurable health impacts.

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Electoral politics influence expansion and titling of informal urban settlements

2026-05-18 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2421303123

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Abstract. Understanding what and who shapes urban growth and how it unfolds in the Global South is critical to ensure theories and predictive models of urban expansion and, consequently, global environmental change, are salient to contemporary contexts. Much of the urban expansion in the Global South occurs in informal settlements where urbanization is not officially permitted and residents often lack access to basic services and infrastructure. As a result, formalizing settlements becomes an asset for political transactions where politicians provide titles and improve conditions in exchange for residents' votes. Yet the cumulative effect of these political transactions on land change remains unknown, rendering electoral dynamics absent from land system science models of urbanization. Here we use panel regression to examine the influence of electoral cycles and voting patterns on urban expansion and formalization of property titles from 1997-2015 in Mexico City. We find the distribution of land titles to residents increases in the months leading up to local elections, and more titles are given to core voting neighborhoods of the historically dominant party. Furthermore, urban built-up area increases in districts with higher electoral competition. These results demonstrate that electoral politics influence when and where the legal city boundary expands, who can access secure tenure, and potentially which settlements grow. These results imply sociopolitical dynamics shape urban sustainability. Incorporating quantified links between political dynamics and urban expansion could improve models of future urban growth and identify relevant levers to improve urban sustainability.

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How rising ICE activity influences the childcare workforce

2026-05-18 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2602686123

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Abstract. Immigrants play a critical role in the US childcare workforce, yet little is known about how immigration enforcement shapes employment in this essential sector. We study how the sharp escalation in community-based Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) activity following President Trump's inauguration in early 2025 affected childcare employment in the United States. Monthly data from the Current Population Survey are linked to compiled state-level ICE arrest records from September 2023 through September 2025, to ask how changes in enforcement intensity influence employment across childcare settings that differ in regulation and visibility. We find that increased ICE activity led to significant declines in employment among foreign-born women, with effects concentrated in center-based settings that are highly regulated and publicly visible. At the same time, employment in private household childcare increased, consistent with a reallocation toward less visible and less formal arrangements rather than a complete exit from the sector. These effects strengthened markedly after early 2025, a period characterized both by a sharp rise in nonprison ICE arrests and heightened public attention to immigration enforcement. Among native-born women, employment responses are limited in magnitude and confined to a limited number of specific care settings, providing little evidence of broad substitution for foreign-born workers. Overall, the results show that immigration enforcement reshapes not only the size but also the structure of the childcare workforce, with important potential implications for childcare access, labor markets, and families.

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Systemic electioneering from the evangelical pulpit: Evidence from a computational analysis

2026-05-18 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2603911123

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Abstract. Religious institutions' engagement in prohibited electoral advocacy is a growing concern for democratic governance. In the United States, such mobilization has been especially visible within the evangelical movement. We examine this phenomenon using a corpus of 88,546 sermons from predominantly evangelical churches, transcribed from 63,683 h of Sunday services spanning the 2020, 2022, and 2024 election cycles and a nonelection control period. Analysis of this corpus reveals that direct political advocacy and endorsements are widespread: 14.7% of churches engaged in this speech during the three months surrounding the 2024 election. This behavior follows a clear electoral rhythm, peaking on the Sunday before Election Day, when 3.5% of churches mobilized. Geographic analysis indicates that advocacy correlates with county partisan composition but lacks strategic targeting; rates in swing states are indistinguishable from those in safe states. Our results provide large-scale quantification of political speech from American pulpits that constitutes prohibited electioneering under current Internal Revenue Service (IRS) guidelines, revealing a pattern of base mobilization driven by local partisan context rather than national electoral strategy.

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Nature Human Behaviour

Why social media research has failed policy-makers

2026-05-22 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02482-9

Tobias Dahl; Njal Foldnes; Steffen Grønneberg; Craig Aaen-Stockdale

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Status quo bias drives public support for drug policy in the USA

2026-05-20 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02471-Y

Bence Hamrak; Gabor Simonovits

Abstract. Abstract Substance regulation in the USA is in a crisis. Here we explore whether seemingly misaligned policies contradict public preferences or reflect biased citizen opinions. Using survey data ($N = 5,053$), we show that policy outcomes align with public opinion. We further demonstrate that regulatory preferences are driven by status quo bias: support for the legality of legal substances exceeds that for hypothetical drugs with corresponding properties (median drug = 39.33, 95% confidence interval 35.34 to 43.20), while the opposite holds for illegal drugs (median drug = 12.59, 95% confidence interval 15.44 to 9.87). Randomly assigning individuals to information about harm attenuates the status quo bias in the case of legal substances (median drug = 17.70, 95% confidence interval 22.35 to 13.05) but not for illegal ones. We discuss implications for public control over drug policies.

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Nature Communications

Counterfactual evaluation of elementary and secondary school policies in the COVID-19 pandemic

2026-05-23 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-73344-1

Benedetta Canfora; Rey Audie Escosio; Otilia Boldea; Ana Nunes; Ganna Rozhnova

Abstract. Abstract Understanding the role of elementary and secondary schools in SARS-CoV-2 transmission is essential for designing effective public health policies. We developed a stochastic age-stratified transmission model, fitted to Dutch epidemiological and contact survey data, to evaluate how alternative closure and reopening strategies for elementary and secondary schools might have shaped the course of the pandemic in the Netherlands from early 2020 through late 2021. Using counterfactual simulations combined with time-varying elasticity analysis, we found that school closures had the potential to mitigate transmission and reduce burden on healthcare. However, their effectiveness was highly context-dependent, influenced by school type, contact patterns, policy timing, and population immunity. Our findings indicate that the contributions of different age groups to transmission shifted over time. Adults were the primary drivers early in the pandemic, followed by adolescents in late 2020 and early 2021, and children in late 2021. These dynamics were reflected in the changing relative impact of different educational levels on overall transmission and hospital burden. Secondary schools had a greater effect on national hospitalizations in 2020, while elementary schools became more important in 2021, partly due to lower prior infection-induced immunity and negligible vaccination coverage among children compared to adolescents. Together, these results highlight the importance of accounting for age-specific transmission dynamics and changing epidemiological landscape when evaluating school closure and reopening strategies. Our study supports a more targeted and adaptive approach to school policies in future pandemics.

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How regional characteristics drive various human mobility types across Europe

2026-05-21 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-73288-6

Milad Malekzadeh; Tuomas Vaisanen; Anastasia Panori; Vicente Royuela; Olle Jarv

Abstract. Spatial mobility of people between regions is critically shaped by socioeconomic landscapes, influencing and being influenced by regional characteristics, especially amid the on-going green and digital transitions. However, this is often studied through the lens of a single mobility type, overlooking the diverse factors driving different forms of movement. This study examines the distinct impacts of regional characteristics on seven types of mobility-permanent migration, long-term and short-term student mobility, seasonal work, long-distance and cross-border commuting, and multilocal living arrangements-across European regions. By integrating data from the Labor Force Survey, Erasmus + , and Twitter, we show how regional characteristics have different effects regarding each mobility type influenced by unique combinations of economic, environmental, and social factors. These differences underscore the limitations of a one-size-fits-all approach in addressing interregional spatial mobility, highlight the need for policies tailored both to specific types of mobility and regional

characteristics. Considering these insights, we present avenues for targeted policy recommendations towards enhancing regional attractiveness and supporting balanced territorial development.

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